

My grandfather, עליו השלום, השם ינקום דמו, was a Belzer חסיד. He was murdered by the Nazis. So there is some chassidish background in my family. My father was not a chassidish Yid. However, after Papa עליו השלום, נפטר, I started wearing his גרטל because Mama gave it to me. I took that upon myself as perhaps a commemoration or symbol of some of my own background.

Many years ago Rabbi Oelbaum gave me a scorecard of the chassidish masters. חסידות started with the בעל שם. One of his many תלמידים was the מגיד of Mezritch, a gigantic personality. His student was Reb Shmelke of Nikolsburg. You may have heard of some of these names. If anybody's interested, you can get back to me and I'll tell you where these places are and what they represent.

חסיד of Berdichev, זכותו יגן עלינו, one of our favorite people of the entire universe, became a חסיד through Reb Shmelke of Nikolsburg. After that he became a תלמיד of the מגיד of Mezritch, as Reb Shmelke introduced him. רב נחמן of Breslov said that the day that רבי לוי יצחק was נפטר, the entire world went dark. And the Ruzhiner, רבי ישראל מרוז'ין, was a grandson of the מגיד of Mezritch. The Belzer Rebbe was one of the glorious products of that tradition, and that is my connection to them.

The vort I'm about to tell you is a חסידישע ווארט with a powerful lesson to transmit to all of us, and it comes from this week's פרשה, פרשת נח. The pasuk says (6:16), צַהַר תַּעֲשֶׂה לַתֶּבֶה, which we know means that there was going to be a lighting mechanism for the תבה, they couldn't sit there pitch black. Rashi brings down that it was either a window or it was a brilliant jewel to light up the תבה. The vort from the בעל שם is, צַהַר תַּעֲשֶׂה לַתֶּבֶה. The word תֶּבֶה can mean ark, and it also can mean the word "word". So what the בעל שם says is, make the words of your davening light up; the words of your davening should not be just rote.

Here comes the מעשה. It's powerful and a little bit harsh, but pay attention. In the days of the בעל שם, there was a man who saw in a ספר that anyone who for 40 days consecutively did not speak any שיחת חולין would be granted רוח הקודש. He took upon himself to go 40 days without saying any word, without talking, to be certain that he would not speak שיחת חולין. However, after the 40 days, to no one's surprise, nothing happened. So he decided to journey to the בעל שם for an explanation. When he told the בעל שם his sad story, the צדיק asked him, "Did you daven during those 40 days?" "What a question, Three times a day, of course!" "Did you read any תהלים?" "Of course", answered the man. "In that case", said the בעל שם, "considering the way that you daven and say תהלים, it's clear now. That must have been your שיחת חולין."

That is a powerful message to all of us, including me. We've got to work on our davening, our learning, and on our תהלים. Rattling off the words is not sufficient. We have to light up our words. We have to make our words illuminated and glorious, mean them and know what we're saying, at least certainly פשוט טייטש. That's why I like my Artscroll סידורים, and I'm constantly looking up words to see what they mean. Frequently I come across a word that I've been saying for many years and I say, "Gee, what does that word mean?" So, we have to work on that. And in the צַהַר תַּעֲשֶׂה לַתֶּבֶה of זכות, may all of our תפילות be מקבל this beautiful new year, and משיח צדקנו, should grace us with his very early coming.

